stated – with some hyperbole – that '[I] was told more barefaced lies than I have ever heard in so short a time'.[41]

Shortly before Kennedy' speech, Moscow learned the President was about to make a televised broadcast. In the early hours of 23 October (Moscow Time), Khrushchev assembled the Presidium. They waited to hear whether Kennedy would announce military action against Cuba (or indeed some new initiative over Berlin). An agitated Khrushchev told his colleagues: 'The thing is we were not going to unleash war … We just wanted to intimidate them, to deter the anti-Castro forces.'[42] The gamble of sending nuclear missiles in secret, while actively deceiving Washington, had very nearly succeeded in presenting Kennedy with a *fait accompli.* Now faced with possible US military action, Khrushchev was nevertheless determined: 'They can attack us … and we shall we respond.' He told his comrades: 'We may end in a big war.'[43]

Kennedy's televised address began at 2.00 am Moscow time. When Khrushchev learned its content, he did not experience any physical or moral shock. There was relief within the Presidium that Kennedy had not announced immediate military action. The next day, Khrushchev publicly denounced the naval blockade as a serious threat to peace. It was a 'gross violation of the Charter of the United Nations and … violation of international norms of freedom of navigation on [the] high seas.' [44] The Soviet Premier reasserted previous claims that the armaments for Cuba were 'destined exclusively for defensive purposes'. He warned Kennedy that failure of the United States to 'show prudence and renounce the measures pursued by you … could lead to catastrophic consequences for peace throughout the world.'

Moscow's response was to press on with Operation Anadyr. Work accelerated at the missile sites. The Soviet freighter carrying the remaining nuclear warheads intended for Cuba, the *Aleksandrovsk,* made a successful dash for the port of La Isabela. Four Soviet Project 641 submarines were ordered to move through the blockade. Unbeknownst to US officials, these diesel-electric attack boats each carried a nuclear-armed torpedo. There was debate in the Presidium over the wisdom of continuing the submarine deployment and Anastas Mikoyan believed he had convinced Khrushchev